

GPT-Live: OpenAI's Full-Duplex Voice AI Ends the Turn-Taking Era

OpenAI launched **GPT-Live** on July 8, 2026, retiring the “Advanced Voice Mode” that had served as its primary voice experience. The transition marks a fundamental architectural change: from turn-based voice interaction — where you speak, the model thinks, the model speaks — to a **full-duplex system** where listening and speaking happen simultaneously.

Why Full-Duplex Changes Everything

Turn-based voice AI has a distinctive rhythm: you finish speaking, there's a pause while the model processes, then you hear a response. That pause — anywhere from 0.8 to 3 seconds depending on the system — is not just a latency issue. It's a conversational signal that communicates “the AI is thinking now, please wait.” It creates a walkie-talkie dynamic that shapes how people talk to AI systems: in complete, deliberate sentences, not in the overlapping, interruptive flow of natural human conversation.

GPT-Live eliminates that signal entirely. The system processes audio continuously, making decisions multiple times per second about whether to speak, listen, pause, or acknowledge. Users can interrupt mid-sentence, change topic, correct themselves, or ask follow-up questions without waiting for a turn boundary. The model tracks all of this without losing the thread of the conversation.

Natural conversational fillers — “mhmm,” “got it,” “right” — are built into GPT-Live's response behaviour. The model is trained to use these acknowledgements in real-time, giving users auditory feedback that they're being heard without having to wait for a full response to confirm the model is tracking.

Full-duplex voice AI isn't just faster — it changes the conversational contract between humans and AI systems entirely.

Task Delegation and Multimodal Integration

One technically interesting design choice in GPT-Live is how it handles complex tasks during an ongoing conversation. The voice layer manages the live audio stream — it never stops listening — but it can offload reasoning-intensive work to backend models (such as GPT-5.5) running in parallel. The results of those computations surface as voice responses or as visual cards displayed on screen, without interrupting the conversational flow.

This means GPT-Live can look up a weather forecast, run a web search, or query a database mid-conversation and deliver the results verbally while the user continues talking. The result feels less like using a tool and more like speaking to an assistant who can act on requests without requiring you to pause and wait.

Multimodal display integration extends this further: GPT-Live can surface visual cards for financial data, sports scores, maps, or media recommendations alongside spoken responses. The screen and the voice channel operate in parallel rather than in sequence.

Live Translation

Because GPT-Live processes audio continuously without buffering full utterances before translating, it supports **live simultaneous translation** during ongoing conversations. Two

speakers can converse in different languages with GPT-Live handling real-time interpretation — a capability that previously required dedicated hardware and specialised interpreters.

The practical applications span multilingual business meetings, travel assistance, language learning, and accessibility use cases where real-time comprehension matters.

Availability and Tiers

GPT-Live-1 — the larger, more capable model — is available to paid subscribers on Go, Plus, and Pro plans. **GPT-Live-1 mini**, a lighter optimised version, serves as the default for Free users. Both models are accessible through the ChatGPT app on iOS, Android, and the web. Developer API access was placed on a waitlist at launch, with OpenAI indicating broader access would follow. As of early August, video and screen-sharing capabilities are not yet supported but are in development.

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